

Weber 2013 Claude Guide

Weber, Max. 2013. *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology* (eds. and trans. H.H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills). Hoboken: Routledge. pp. 77–83, excerpt from “Politics as a Vocation” (*Politik als Beruf*).

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1 A Note on This Excerpt

- Pages 77–83 are the *opening* of “Politics as a Vocation,” before Weber turns to the sociology of the professional politician, parties, and the “ethic of responsibility” vs. “ethic of ultimate ends” that occupy the bulk of the essay. This is a short excerpt (roughly 6–7 pages), so this guide is scoped tightly to what those pages actually cover: (1) Weber’s definition of the state via the monopoly of legitimate violence, (2) the three types of legitimate domination as a framing device, and (3) the beginning of the transition into “living for” vs. “living off” politics.
- **Important cross-reference:** the typology of traditional, charismatic, and legal-rational authority appears *here* and, in more developed form, in the separate “Weber 1968” reading in this repository (the “Charismatic Authority / Pure Types of Legitimate Authority” excerpt, likely drawn from *Economy and Society* or a parallel Gerth/Mills selection). Do not confuse the two: this essay uses the typology instrumentally, as a two-page detour to establish *why* political rule requires more than habituation or fear before it pivots to occupational sociology (professional politicians, parties, bureaucracy). The Weber 1968 reading develops the typology as the object of analysis in its own right, with more attention to the internal logic, routinization, and instability of each type. Read them as complementary rather than redundant: same taxonomy, different analytic purpose.

2 Central Claims

- Politics, for Weber, means “striving to share power or striving to influence the distribution of power, either among states or among groups within a state.” The essay’s opening move is to define the **state** itself, since “politics” only makes sense once we know what kind of association is being contested.
- The state cannot be defined by *what* it does (all manner of associations perform welfare, adjudication, economic functions); it can only be defined sociologically by its distinctive **means**: the state is “a human community that (successfully) claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory.”
- Because the state monopolizes legitimate violence, all other associations and individuals possess the “right” to use force only to the extent the state permits or delegates it. Violence is not the state’s *only* tool, but it is the state’s *specific*, defining one—the ultima ratio behind law and order.
- Legitimacy, not mere coercive capacity, is what makes domination (*Herrschaft*) stable and distinguishes a state from a criminal gang holding territory by force alone. The question “why do people obey?” is therefore prior to any account of policy or institutions.
- Weber answers that question with the three ideal-typical grounds of legitimacy: **tradition**, **charisma**, and **legality/rational rules**. Real domination is always a mixture, but the

typology isolates the pure logics that make obedience durable rather than accidental or momentary.

- This sets up the essay’s pivot: if rule requires legitimation beyond force, then the people who run states—politicians, officials, staffs of domination—become a sociologically distinctive group, and the essay proceeds to ask how one can “live for” politics as a vocation, and who is economically able to do so.

3 The State Defined by the Monopoly of Legitimate Violence

- The famous formulation: the state is the entity that “(successfully) claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory.” Three components do the work: (1) *claims*—a normative assertion, not a bare description; (2) *monopoly*—exclusivity, not merely predominance; (3) *legitimate*—force must be authorized, recognized as rightful, not simply exercised.
- This is a deliberately amoral, non-normative definition: Weber is not saying the state *should* monopolize violence, or that this monopoly is good. He is offering a value-neutral sociological criterion that lets us identify “the state” across radically different historical and cultural forms (feudal, absolutist, constitutional, revolutionary) without smuggling in a particular political theory of what the state is *for*.
- Consequence: every other body—churches, families, corporations, unions, individuals—may use force only where the state has permitted or delegated that right (e.g., parental chastisement historically, private security, self-defense). The state is thus the ultimate source and arbiter of the “right to violence” in a territory; other actors hold delegated fragments of it, revocable in principle.
- Politics in the specific sense Weber means (as opposed to “politics” colloquially applied to any organization’s internal power struggles) is inseparable from this monopoly: to be “political” is to be oriented toward influencing the distribution of, or control over, the apparatus that wields legitimate coercion.
- This definitional move is what makes the rest of the essay possible: because the stakes of politics are ultimately about who controls legitimate violence, the question of *why anyone obeys* those who hold it becomes the central sociological problem—hence the turn to legitimacy and the three types.
- Note the definition is explicitly territorial (“within a given territory”)—a reminder that Weber’s state concept is bound up with the modern, bounded, spatially exclusive polity, in contrast to overlapping medieval jurisdictions or personal/dynastic rule.

4 The Three Types of Legitimate Domination (as Framing Device Here)

- Weber asks: “when and why do men obey?” Every system of domination attempts to cultivate and cultivate belief in its own legitimacy; he distinguishes three pure (ideal-typical) internal justifications:
 1. **Traditional authority:** legitimacy rests on “the authority of the ‘eternal yesterday,’” the sanctity of age-old rules and powers, habituated to as sacred and unquestionable. The patriarch, the chieftain, the traditional prince rules because “it has always been so.”
 2. **Charismatic authority:** legitimacy rests on “the authority of the extraordinary and personal gift of grace (charisma), the absolutely personal devotion and personal confidence in revelation, heroism, or other qualities of individual leadership.” The prophet, the war hero, the demagogue rules by virtue of exceptional, often supernatural or superhuman, personal qualities recognized by followers.
 3. **Legal-rational authority:** legitimacy rests on “a belief in the validity of legal statute and functional ‘competence’ based on rationally created rules.” Obedience is owed not to a person but to enacted, impersonal rules and to the office/position occupying a position within them—the modern bureaucratic official is the paradigmatic bearer of this type.
- Weber’s purpose here is narrower than in a full treatment (as in *Economy and Society*): he introduces the typology specifically to establish that **obedience is never simply a function of fear or habit**—every durable system of rule requires an “inner justification” recognized by the ruled, and the type of justification shapes the type of ruling staff (administrative apparatus) that develops around it.
- This is a brief treatment relative to the fuller elaboration in the Weber 1968 reading, which develops the internal dynamics of each type at length (e.g., the routinization of charisma, patrimonialism as a variant of traditional authority, the specific features of bureaucratic administration). Here the typology functions as a springboard: having established that political rule always rests on one (or a blend) of these legitimating grounds, Weber can proceed to ask what kind of human beings—professional politicians—come to staff and personify these different structures of domination.
- Practical payoff for the essay’s argument: the modern state increasingly rests on *legal-rational* legitimacy administered by a professional bureaucracy, which is precisely the backdrop against which Weber will pose his central occupational question: is there still room, within a legal-rational, bureaucratized state apparatus, for the charismatic political leader (and for genuine political leadership as opposed to mere administration)?

5 Politics and the Professional Politician

- Having established that the state is defined by legitimate violence and that legitimate domination requires a staff (administrative apparatus) to carry it out, Weber turns to the people who actually run politics: this excerpt begins the transition into his sociology of the political vocation.
- Central distinction (elaborated more fully just past p. 83, but framed here): one can relate to politics either by living **“for” politics** (making politics one’s calling in an existential/vocational sense, deriving meaning and purpose from the exercise of power, typically requiring independent wealth or a marginal relationship to material need) or by living **“off” politics** (treating political office as a stable source of income, a livelihood).
- These are not mutually exclusive in practice, but they mark an analytic distinction Weber uses to trace the historical emergence of a distinct social class of **professional politicians**—people whose vocation, and often livelihood, is the pursuit and exercise of political power, as opposed to notables who dabble in politics as an avocation alongside independent economic means.
- This sets up (beyond p. 83) Weber’s historical sociology of who has been able to afford to “live for” politics across different eras and regime types (patrimonial officials, clergy, lawyers, journalists, party bosses), and how the professionalization and bureaucratization of party machines transforms the vocation of politics in modern mass democracies.

6 Core Works Cited/Context

- **Origins:** “Politics as a Vocation” (*Politik als Beruf*) originated as a lecture delivered by Weber in Munich in January 1919, to the Free Students’ Union (Freistudentische Bund), amid the chaos of the German Revolution and the collapse of the Wilhelmine state—a context that gives urgency to Weber’s concern with legitimacy, charismatic leadership, and the fate of politics in a disenchanted, bureaucratized age.
- **Companion piece:** “Science as a Vocation” (*Wissenschaft als Beruf*), delivered as a companion lecture in the same series (November 1917), addresses the vocation of the scholar under conditions of rationalization and “disenchantment” (*Entzauberung*). The two lectures are often read together as Weber’s meditation on what remains of meaningful vocation—scientific truth-seeking, political leadership—once the world has been thoroughly rationalized and stripped of magical/religious meaning.
- **Broader systematic treatment:** The typology of domination and the state-as-monopoly-of-violence definition are elaborated at much greater length and rigor in *Economy and Society* (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*), Weber’s unfinished magnum opus, particularly the sections on the sociology of domination (*Herrschaftssoziologie*). “Politics as a Vocation” popularizes and condenses this systematic sociology for a lay/student audience.

- **Gerth and Mills’ *From Max Weber***: this 1946 English-language anthology (the source of the assigned excerpt) was instrumental in introducing Weber to Anglophone social science, and its translations (including “monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force,” “ideal type,” “disenchantment of the world”) have become the standard English vocabulary for Weberian concepts in comparative politics and sociology.

7 Methodological/Conceptual Notes

- The three types of legitimate domination are, once again, **ideal types** (*Idealtypen*)—analytical constructs that isolate the pure logic of a phenomenon by exaggerating and abstracting its defining features, not empirical descriptions of any real historical regime. No actual state is purely traditional, charismatic, or legal-rational; all mix elements (e.g., a hereditary monarch backed by a modern bureaucracy; a charismatic president operating within a constitutional-legal order).
- The state definition itself functions the same way: an ideal-typical criterion for identifying “stateness” that can be approximated to greater or lesser degrees (failed states, contested sovereignty, and civil war are precisely cases where the empirical monopoly of legitimate violence breaks down or is contested—see Kalyvas below).
- Weber’s approach is explicitly **value-neutral** (*wertfrei*): defining the state by its means (violence) rather than its ends (justice, welfare, order) is a methodological choice to keep sociological analysis free of normative political theorizing about what states *ought* to do. This is consistent with Weber’s broader methodological commitments to a science of social action that explains via *Verstehen* (interpretive understanding of subjective meaning) without smuggling in the analyst’s own values.
- The recurring puzzle across Weber’s sociology of domination: legitimacy is always a matter of *belief* among the ruled, not an objective property of the ruler. This subjectivist, meaning-centered approach to authority is continuous with Weber’s general sociological method (social action is defined by the subjective meaning actors attach to it).

8 Connections to the Broader Literature

- **Weber 1968 (Charismatic Authority / Pure Types of Legitimate Authority)**: Direct overlap—the same three-fold typology (traditional, charismatic, legal-rational) is the shared analytic core of both readings. Here it is a compressed framing device en route to the sociology of the professional politician; there it is developed and analyzed in its own right (internal logic of each type, routinization of charisma, patrimonial and bureaucratic variants). Read as two passes over the same taxonomy at different levels of resolution and for different purposes.
- **Weber 1930 (*The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*)**: Both readings are part of Weber’s broader diagnosis of Western **rationalization**. *The Protestant*

Ethic traces how ascetic Protestant ethics unintentionally rationalized economic life into modern capitalism; “Politics as a Vocation” traces how the same rationalizing logic produces legal-rational domination and bureaucratic administration as the dominant mode of legitimate authority. Both are case studies in how meaning-laden, often unintended, cultural/religious dynamics generate impersonal, rule-bound modern institutions—and both end on a note of ambivalence about what is lost (charisma, ethical meaning) as rationalization proceeds.

- **Huntington 1968:** Huntington’s institutionalization—the acquisition by organizations and procedures of value and stability—is a close cousin of Weber’s legal-rational authority: both concern how rule becomes legitimated through impersonal, durable rules rather than personal loyalty or charisma. Huntington’s worry about praetorianism (personalistic, unstable rule) maps onto Weber’s concern about the fragility of purely charismatic domination absent routinization into traditional or legal-rational form.
- **Dahl 1972:** Dahl’s polyarchy assumes a functioning, legitimate state monopolizing coercion as the backdrop within which contestation and participation occur; Weber’s essay supplies the prior sociological question Dahl’s institutional analysis takes for granted—what makes a coercive apparatus legitimate (and thus stable enough to support polyarchal contestation) in the first place.
- **Moore 1966:** Moore’s comparative-historical routes to modern regimes (democracy, fascism, communism) can be read as historical variations in how the legal-rational/bureaucratic state came to monopolize violence and displace older traditional (landed aristocratic) bases of authority—different national “settlements” of the traditional-to-legal-rational transition Weber theorizes abstractly.
- **Putnam 1993:** Putnam’s civic community argument concerns the social preconditions for effective, responsive government once formal (legal-rational) institutions are already in place; Weber’s essay is more concerned with the prior legitimation problem of authority itself. Putnam’s low-civic-community regions with clientelism and patronage resemble a partial reversion toward more particularistic, quasi-traditional bases of political relationship within a nominally legal-rational state.
- **Cox 1997:** Cox’s analysis of electoral coordination and party systems presupposes a legal-rational state administering elections under stable rules; the professionalization of politicians and parties that Weber traces (just past this excerpt) is the historical precondition for the kind of strategic, rule-bound party competition Cox models.
- **Lijphart 1999:** Lijphart’s majoritarian/consensus typology of democratic institutions operates entirely within the legal-rational frame Weber describes—both assume a state whose legitimacy is settled and ask how power is subsequently organized and constrained within it.
- **Huber and Shipan 2002:** Their account of statutory control over bureaucratic discretion is a study of legal-rational authority in fine institutional detail—delegation, discretion, and

drafting are precisely the mechanisms by which modern legal-rational states manage the administrative apparatus Weber identifies as the hallmark of this type of domination.

- **Powell 2000:** Powell’s concern with the “chain of responsiveness and accountability” in democracies takes for granted the legal-rational, bureaucratically administered state Weber describes as one (historically contingent) end point of the transition away from traditional and charismatic legitimation.
- **Stokes 2013:** Clientelism, Stokes’ subject, is in Weberian terms a hybrid or partial reversion—exchange relationships that substitute particularistic, quasi-personal ties for impersonal legal-rational entitlement, even within nominally legal-rational modern states; directly illuminates how the “pure types” blend and compete in practice.
- **Svolik 2012:** Svolik’s analysis of authoritarian regimes and the problem of controlling the “guardians” of coercive power revisits Weber’s core insight that whoever controls the state’s monopoly of legitimate (or simply effective) violence controls the ultimate stakes of politics; the succession and power-sharing problems Svolik documents are recurring failures to institutionalize (in Weber’s terms, to root in tradition or legal-rational rule) a charismatic or personalist seizure of that monopoly.
- **Carey 2009:** Carey’s work on legislative voting and party discipline operates within the assumed legal-rational constitutional order Weber’s essay treats as one historically achieved (not natural or automatic) form of legitimate domination.
- **Kalyvas 2006 (*The Logic of Violence in Civil War*):** Perhaps the most direct substantive connection in this list. Kalyvas’ entire analytic apparatus concerns what happens when the state’s monopoly of legitimate violence—Weber’s defining criterion for stateness—breaks down or becomes locally contested: civil war, on this reading, is precisely the empirical unraveling and re-contestation of the Weberian monopoly, with rival armed actors and even civilians competing to establish local, partial monopolies of coercion and their attendant (often thin or coerced) legitimacy. Kalyvas’ distinction between violence used to build local order/legitimacy and violence used purely instrumentally maps productively onto Weber’s insistence that legitimacy, not force alone, is what makes domination stable.